



Tailplane mounted high, out of jet exhaust

◀ MESSERSCHMITT ME 262 SCHWALBE

Date 1944 **Origin** Germany
Wingspan 12.6m (41½ft)
Length 10.6m (34¾ft)
Top speed 870kph (540mph)
Engine Twin 900kg (1,985lb) Junkers Jumo 004B-1 turbojets

The first turbojet-powered combat fighter, the Me 262 quickly proved effective against the US Air Force's daylight bombing campaign, but it was produced too late to affect the outcome of the war.



Large wings needed for heavy aircraft (16 tons)

Four 20mm cannons in belly nacelle

▲ NORTHROP P-61 BLACK WIDOW

Date 1944 **Origin** US
Wingspan 21.1m (66ft)
Length 15.1m (49½ft)
Top speed 590kph (365mph)
Engine Twin 1,677.8kW (2,250hp) Pratt & Whitney R-2800-65W Double Wasp radials

The P-61 was the first US aircraft designed as a night-fighter, and was the first aircraft specifically designed to carry radar for this purpose. It was capable of "loitering" in the skies for up to eight hours at a time.



One 30mm cannon in each wing-root

Swept-back wing form

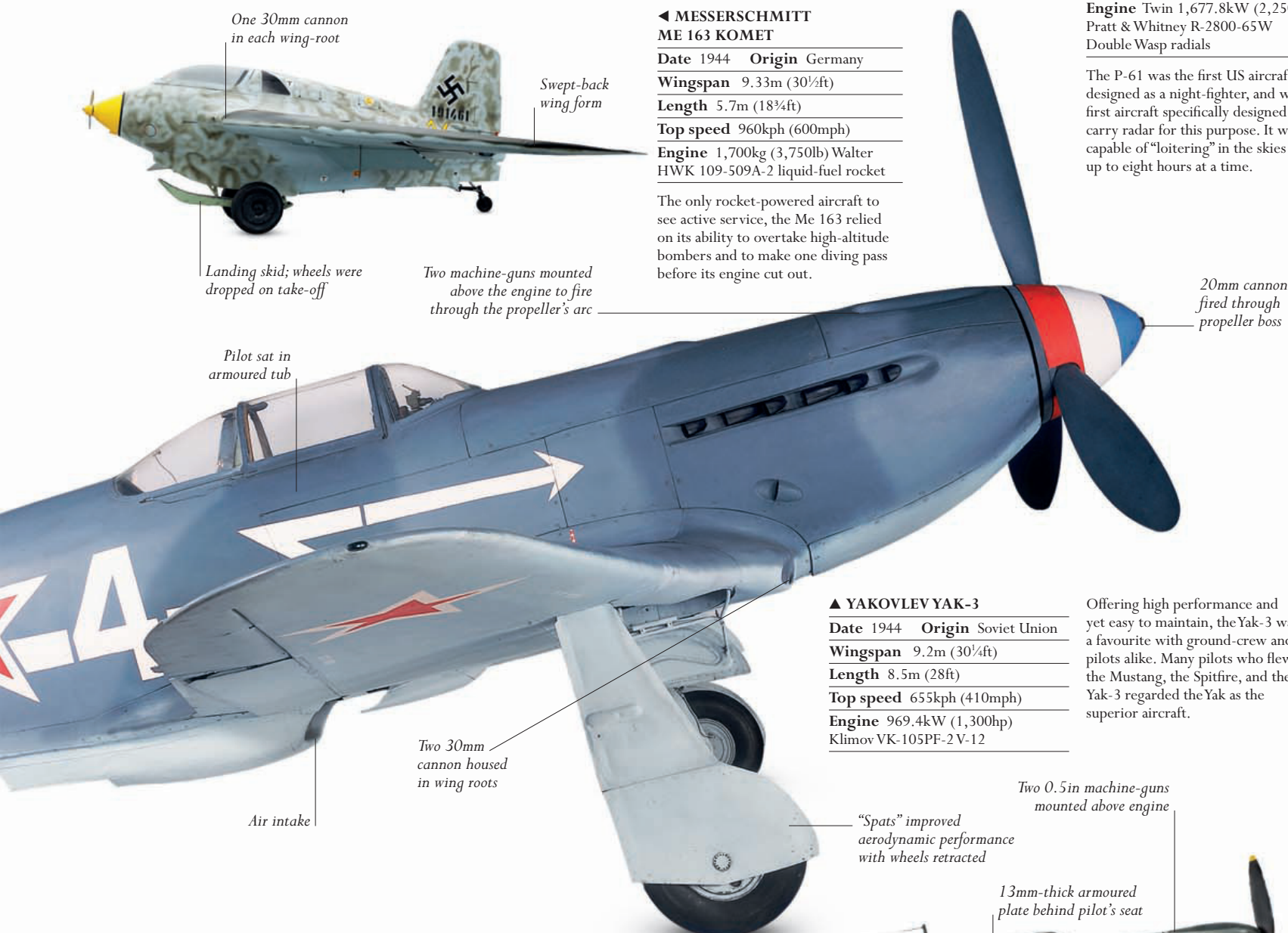
Landing skid; wheels were dropped on take-off

Two machine-guns mounted above the engine to fire through the propeller's arc

◀ MESSERSCHMITT ME 163 KOMET

Date 1944 **Origin** Germany
Wingspan 9.33m (30½ft)
Length 5.7m (18¾ft)
Top speed 960kph (600mph)
Engine 1,700kg (3,750lb) Walter HWK 109-509A-2 liquid-fuel rocket

The only rocket-powered aircraft to see active service, the Me 163 relied on its ability to overtake high-altitude bombers and to make one diving pass before its engine cut out.



Pilot sat in armoured tub

20mm cannon fired through propeller boss

▲ YAKOVLEV YAK-3

Date 1944 **Origin** Soviet Union
Wingspan 9.2m (30¼ft)
Length 8.5m (28ft)
Top speed 655kph (410mph)
Engine 969.4kW (1,300hp) Klimov VK-105PF-2 V-12

Offering high performance and yet easy to maintain, the Yak-3 was a favourite with ground-crew and pilots alike. Many pilots who flew the Mustang, the Spitfire, and the Yak-3 regarded the Yak as the superior aircraft.

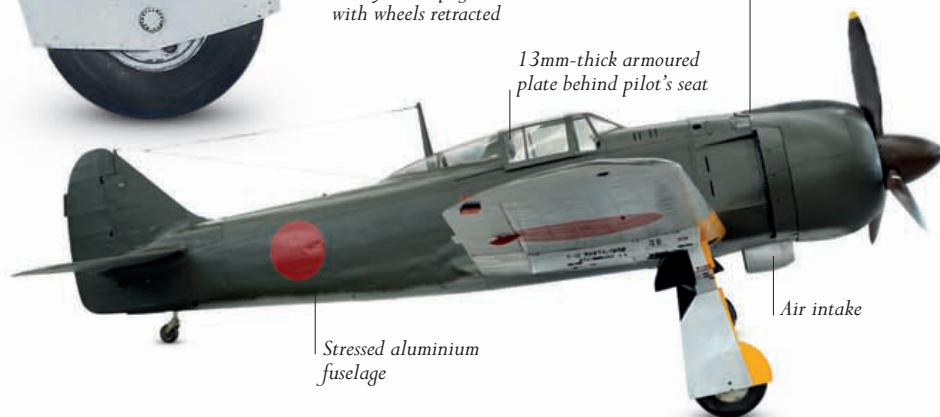
Two 30mm cannon housed in wing roots

Air intake

"Spats" improved aerodynamic performance with wheels retracted

Two 0.5in machine-guns mounted above engine

13mm-thick armoured plate behind pilot's seat



Stressed aluminium fuselage

Air intake

► KAWASAKI KI-100

Date 1945 **Origin** Japan
Wingspan 12m (39¼ft)
Length 8.8m (29ft)
Top speed 580kph (360mph)
Engine 1,118.5kW (1,500hp) Mitsubishi Ha 112-II radial

Influenced by the German Focke-Wulf Fw 190, the Ki-100 was one of the best fighter aircraft the Japanese air force deployed during World War II – highly manoeuvrable and with a high altitude capacity. However, it came too late to make any difference to the outcome of the war.